

On the rocks



A type of brown seaweed (kelp) found in the Pacific Ocean

IN SHALLOW, COOL WATERS above rocky seabeds, forests of kelp (large brown seaweeds) are home for many animals. Fish swim among the giant fronds. Along North America's Pacific coast, sea otters wrap themselves in kelp while asleep on the surface. Tightly gripping the rocks, the kelp's rootlike anchor (holdfast) houses hordes of tiny creatures, such as worms and mites. Unlike the roots of land plants, kelp's holdfast is only an anchor and does not absorb water or nutrients. Other animals grow on the kelp's surface or directly on the rocks and capture food brought to them in the currents. Sea fans look like plants, but are animals belonging to the same group as sea anemones, jellyfish, and corals, and all have stinging tentacles. Anchored to rocks, mussels provide homes for some animals between or within their shells.



DELIGHTFUL MARINE MAMMAL

Sea otters swim and rest among giant kelp fronds along North America's Pacific coast. They dive down to the seabed to pick up shellfish, smashing them open by banging them against a rock balanced on their chest.

ANCHORED ALGAE

Holdfasts of the large, tough, brown algae called kelp keep it firmly anchored to the rocks. Growing in shallow water, kelp is often battered by waves.

Holdfast of oarweed kelp

Holdfast must be strong, as some kinds of kelp can grow tens of metres long

Scaleless body is covered with small warty bumps

Juvenile lump sucker

PRETTY BABY
Young lump suckers are more beautiful than their dumpy parents, which cling onto rocks with suckerlike fins on their bellies. The adult lump suckers come into shallow water to breed and the father guards the eggs.

Each sturdy, blunt finger measures at just over an inch (3 cm) across

Fleshy fingers supported by many, tiny, hard splinters

White, anemone-like polyp captures food from fast-moving currents

DEAD MAN'S FINGERS

When this soft coral is washed up on the shore, its rubbery, fleshy form lives up to its name! Growing on rocks, the colonies consist of many polyps (feeding bodies) within a fleshy, orange, or white base.

Gills

SEA MAT

The lacy-looking growth on the kelp's surface (left) is a bryozoan, or moss animal. They live in colonies where many individuals grow next to each other. Each little compartment houses one of these animals, which come out to feed, capturing food in their tiny tentacles. The colony grows as individuals bud off new individuals. Other kinds of moss animal grow upward, looking like seaweeds or corals. Between the sea mats, a blue-rayed limpet grazes on the kelp's surface.



SEA SLUG

Many sea slugs are meat-eaters. This slug lives on the soft coral known as Dead man's fingers. Some sea slugs are able to eat the stinging tentacles of anemones and keep the stings for their own protection. Sea slug eggs hatch into swimming young, which then settle and turn into adults.